

¿Quieres ir a misa?: Religious Change and Latino Party Identification

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1 Introduction

A couple decades ago, Irreligious people were on the margins of the Latino community, making up only 7% of Latinos at-large. Now, they make up 35%, being statistically tied with Catholics as the largest group in the Latino community. At the same time, Evangelicals are becoming more notable in the political scene (Ramos 2024), being vocal critics of the Democrat establishment in the Latino community. So, do the changing religious landscape of Latinos affect their politics?

Leveraging 29 surveys conducted from 2002 to 2023 with a total n of 97,961, I analyze the shifts in Latino religion and politics through multiple avenues. I use LOESS smoothing estimates for year-religion in an error correction model to find that the rise in Irreligion *causes* the decrease in Catholicism, whereas changes in Evangelicalism do not cause the decrease in Catholicism. Another error correction model finds that change in Irreligion has no effect on change in Democrat identification, though this model is less useful as there has not been very much change in Democrat identification. Finally, I find that, controlling for other variables in a series of OLS regressions, the effect of Evangelicalism on individual Latinos' party identification is not significantly becoming more Republican, though this model suffers from limitations in the data. The implications of this paper are that the massive shift in Irreligion is not massively changing party identification, and there is no shift in Evangelicalism or Evangelical Republican fervor. It seems that the shifting religious landscape of Latinos does not have an outsized impact on party identification in the Latino community.

2 Literature Review

Presently, there are three major groups in Latino religion: Catholics, Irreligious, and Evangelicals (Pew Research Center 2023). Catholicism has been steadily declining, from 67% of Latinos in 2010 to its present 43%, whereas Irreligion has increased from 10% to 30% in the same timeframe (Pew Research Center 2023). Evangelicalism has stayed relatively steady from 12% in 2010 to 15% in 2022.

The Catholic Church has long been one of the few institutions that Latinos from different countries of origin share in common. Many Latino Catholics became Americans as the United States began to expand into formerly Spanish territories, such as Texas, California, Puerto Rico, and Cuba. (Matovina 2014, 5-6). The Church itself has broad issue positions spanning the left-right spectrum, as demonstrated by the Convocation '95, a policy document written by Latino priests (Matovina 2014, 213). From being anti-abortion and anti-death penalty to being pro-immigration rights and in support of alleviating poverty through social programs (Matovina 2014, 213), Church leaders promote a theology that, while consistent within Catholic thought, is split by the American two-party system. Unlike in many other religious traditions, Catholic priests tend to refrain from explicitly endorsing a political party (Matovina 2014, 214), leaving a committed Catholic with little guidance on how to vote their divided conscience. Though willing to cross party lines, for example, in support of George W. Bush in 2004 (Matovina 2014, 207), Matovina notes that “Latino Catholics’ economic concerns, resonance with Catholic teachings about immigration and the social order, and perception that Democrats represent them best on

bread-and-butter issues generally overshadow the attraction of some Latinos to Republicans’ moral traditionalism.” (Matovina 2014, 214). As such, Catholic Latinos are more likely to be ideologically conservative than the average voter, but no more or less likely to be a Republican (Gibson and Hare 2012).

Where Catholic leaders tend to be apolitical, Evangelical leaders tend to be *all-political*. Paola Ramos’ journalistic work in Latino Evangelical communities finds that their political beliefs are deeply tied to their religious belief that America is an ontologically Christian nation soon to be owned by God (Ramos 2024, chapter 4). As such Latinos caught up in this fight often dedicate themselves deeply to reclaiming this country from the forces of the LGBTQ+ agenda that seeks to destroy families and children (Ramos 2024, chapter 5). Ramos opines that “Latinos are also uniquely adept at the type of devotion evangelicalism requires, which is a consistent, intentional attempt to follow the word of God in one’s personal and public life. It’s an all-encompassing form of practice that consumes the entirety of one’s being,” (Ramos 2024, chapter 4). Unsurprisingly, Evangelical Latinos are far more conservative and Republican than Catholic or Irreligious Latinos (Gibson and Hare 2012, 67-68). Evangelicals are also far more likely to oppose same-sex marriage, oppose abortion, support the Iraq War, and support Israel than Catholics, while also being no less likely to support universal healthcare or benefits for the poor (Gibson and Hare 2012, 67-68). Evidently, the rise of Irreligion in Latino communities has spooked a lot of people. But where did the Irreligious come from?

Termed as “Nones” and “Nonverts”, the Irreligious population has grown rapidly, with Irreligious identification increasing by 20% in only 12 years, surpassing Protes-

tants as the second-largest religious identification for Latinos.

Burge notes that despite Protestants and “Nones” having roughly similar numbers, “The Protestant group is further divided into seventy denominations. The religiously unaffiliated are broken down into three categories: atheists, agnostics, and nothing in particular...those three options for identifying as a none are still unduly reductive.” (Burge 2021, chapter 4). He finds that Atheists are the most Democrat and liberal group, with Agnostics being similarly Democrat and liberal, and “Nothing in particulars” being independent and markedly more conservative (Burge 2021, Figure 4.7). Atheists and Agnostics are also more politically active than the average respondent and “Nothing in particulars” (Burge 2021, Figure 4.8). He also finds that Latinos are more likely to identify as “Nothing in particular” than Whites, and less likely to identify as Atheists or Agnostics.

The most remarkable thing about the rise of Irreligion is the sheer speed at which it has taken place. Again, in only 12 years did Irreligion grow by 20% to become the second-largest affiliation in the Latino community (Pew Research Center 2023). Bullivant’s exceptional qualitative work sheds some light on this rise. He interviews a third-generation Mexican-American woman from Los Angeles who recounts that she had never been deeply connected to the Church growing up. “I never felt a connection. Never. Not even as a little child, when you’re supposed to. In eighth grade, when they say ‘You’re blessed now, you’re old enough, you’ve learned enough to accept the Sacrament. And when you accept it, you pray, and you’ll feel special.’” (Bullivant 2022, 174). Despite herself being dragged to mass every Sunday, she noted that many of her “Catholic” peers were not commonly in attendance (Bullivant 2022,

175). This sentiment that Catholic belief is not commonly endogenous (using the plain meaning of that word) among younger Catholics is cited by Bullivant as a part of the Church’s decline: ”Cultural Catholicism, when not packaged up with personally owned belief and practice, only passes on for a generation or two: the children who were baptized only to please their Polish, Mexican, or Bostonian grandmothers will not grow up needing to placate their own mother when it comes to their offspring.” (Bullivant 2022, 188). There is also often a perception that the Church is too harsh for the modern world, as “extremely conservative: anti-sex, anti-condoms, anti-women” as one Catholic nonvert describes it (Bullivant 2022, 188), while at once being hypocritical, given its rampant problems with sex abuse (Bullivant 2022, 189-192). These perspectives end up permeating public opinion, as Irreligious Latinos are more Democratic and more liberal than Catholics or Evangelicals (Gibson and Hare 2012). Gershon, Pantoja, and Taylor (2016) find that younger generations are less likely to be religious, though this decline in religiosity is not correlated with a decline in political participation (Gershon et al. 2016, 97-104).

3 Theory

I come away with a few thoughts on these trends. Given that Irreligiosity is correlated with more liberal ideology and Democratic identification, it could be the case that this rise in Irreligiosity leads to a rise in Democratic identification overall:

H1: A positive change in Irreligiosity causes a positive change in Democratic identification.

Alternatively, it could be the case that many of these newly minted Irreligious

people are simply the liberal-leaning Catholics of the last generation, in which case:

$H1_0$: A positive change in Irreligiosity has no effect on Democratic identification.

Ramos, citing Mark Mulderc(Ramos 2024, chapter 4), alternatively puts forth that Evangelicalism, rather than Irreligion, is the a driver of a rising “Latino Far Right”. As such, it would be useful to test two more things:

$H2$: Change in irreligiosity has a greater effect than change in Evangelicalism on change in Catholicism.

$H3$: Change in Evangelicalism is causing greater Republican identification among Evangelical Latinos in the present, as opposed to the past.

4 Methods

Time-series cross-sectional analysis seeks to explain cointegration (correlation) of a time-series (series of measurements across time) with explanatory variables’ time-series. Time-series models are better at establishing causality because of their measurement of causes and effects in time (generally causality requires that a cause precedes an effect) while still being able to control for multiple independent variables.

I am using different methods for the different hypotheses.

An Error Correction Model (de Boef and Keele 2008) can test for the effects of *change* of explanatory variables on change in dependent variables. The Error Correction Model takes the form of

$$\Delta Y_t = \alpha_0 + \alpha_1 Y_{t-1} + \beta_0 \Delta X_t + \beta_1 X_{t-1} + \cdots + \epsilon_t$$

as in (de Boef and Keele 2008, 190), where t is a time period, ΔY_t is the change in the dependent variable from one period to the previous period, α_0 is the constant, Y_{t-1} is the dependent variable level lagged by one time period, ΔX_t is the change in the independent variable, and X_{t-1} is the independent variable level lagged by one period. This methodology is used to test H1 and H2 where independent variables are change and lag in Irreligion and Evangelicalism and dependent variables are change in Catholicism and Democrat identification, all as percentages.

To test hypothesis three, a basic OLS regression is run for the effect of Evangelicalism on Democrat party identification, controlling for gender, education and age. Gender is binary, education is ordinal with less than high school, high school, some college, and college graduate, and age is numeric. Evangelical identification is binary and party ID is coded on a scale from Republican (-1) to Democrat (1). These coefficients are then plotted and another OLS regression is run to see if these coefficients become larger or smaller across years. This method was suggested by Christopher Wlezien. Other methods, such as Rolling Window Regression (Zivot and Wang 2006) are used for time-series and cannot deal with more than one point in each time period.

5 Data

The main limitation throughout this project is data. The only yearly time series that could be used for this paper is the CCES 2006-2023, but the main limitation of the CCES is that it does not sample in Spanish. This necessarily biases the data in certain ways. For example, across most years, the Irreligious population is around

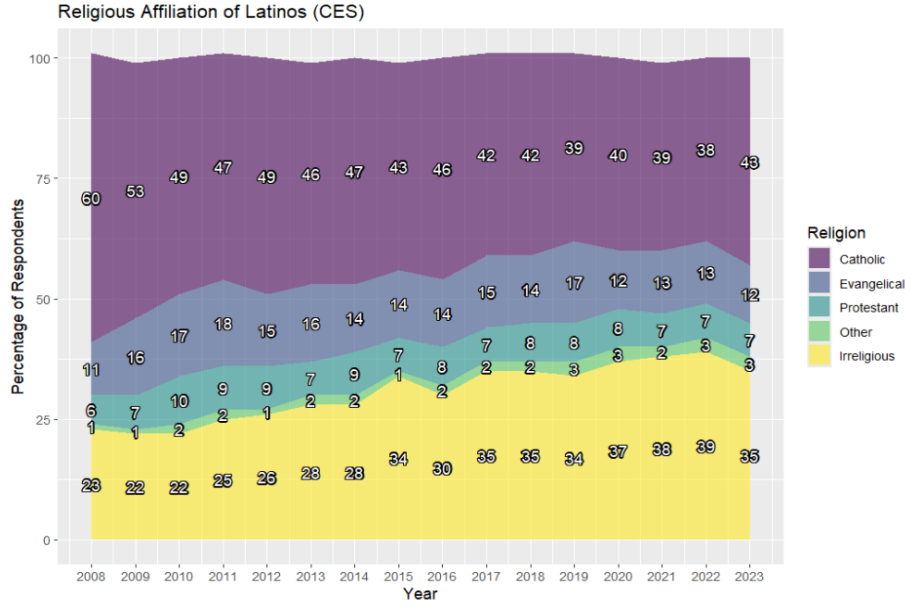


Figure 1

10% higher than the population reported by Pew. In addition, there is a sawtooth pattern between 2010 and 2019, meaning that their sampling may be less reliable in non-election years.

Pew's surveys are better because they oversample for Latinos and have Spanish surveys. On the other hand, Pew's data only goes to 2018 and is not a consistent time series because it does not have samples for all years (no reliable datasets for 2003-2005, 2007-2008, 2017), leaving gaps in coverage between years that break many time-series models. Finally, other possible datasets do not have the necessary variables for the research design (CMPS 2008-2012 no 7 point PID, CMPS 2016 no born again, LNS and LNPS no Irreligious option, RLS [all years] no origin county question).

For the final data, 29 datasets are merged to get estimates for religion and party identification from 2002 to 2023. These datasets are taken from the Latino party

identification generational turnover project by Fraga, Wakefield, and Fisk (2025), and Derek Wakefield’s replication code is extensively used for the cleaning of the data and reweighing of survey data (Fraga et al. 2025). Survey data is reweighted against census counts for education, gender, geography, and Latino origin group (Mexican, Puerto Rican, etc.). To create time-series from these datasets, LOESS regression is used to create a regression curve for percent estimates of Democrats, Republicans, Independents, Catholics, Evangelicals, Irreligious, Protestants, and Other Religions. The LOESS curves’ spans are optimized with AICC to reduce error of smoothing parameter election from other methods (Hurvich et al. 1998). These regression curves are used to predict estimates for each year, and these estimates are used in the error correction model.

There are benefits and drawbacks to using the methodology. The benefit is that idiosyncracies of specific datasets have less of an effect on the final models, making the measure more valid. On the other hand, creating estimates from LOESS comes with some amount of error that is not controlled for in the error correction model, making the final models less reliable. I still believe this is the best alternative to using the CCES time-series alone, as the problems with validity for Latino measurements in the CCES are immense.

Table 1: Surveys Used

Survey	n
Kaiser-Pew 2002	2929
Pew 2004	2288
Pew 2006	2000
CES 2008	2000
CES 2009	1441
Pew 2009	2012
CES 2010	5617
Pew 2010	1375
CES 2011	1751
Pew 2011	1220
CES 2012	5599
Pew 2012	1765
CES 2013	1672
Pew 2013	5103
CES 2014	5659
Pew 2014	1520
CES 2015	1729
Pew 2015	1500
CES 2016	7495
Pew 2016	1507
CES 2017	3248
CES 2018	6977
Pew 2018	1501
CES 2019	2518
CES 2020	6978
CMPS 2020	4104
CES 2021	4066
CES 2022	7819
CES 2023	4298
Total	97691

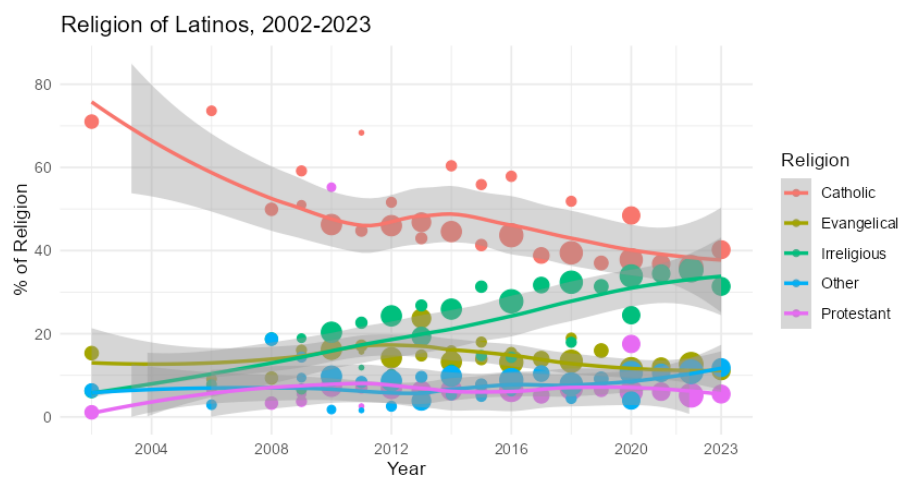


Figure 2

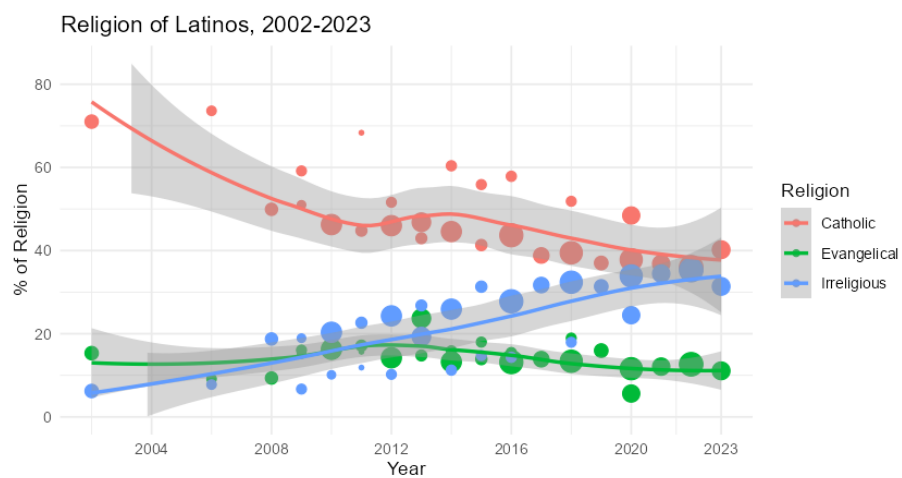


Figure 3

Table 2

	dy	
	y = $\Delta\%Catholic$	y = $\Delta\%Democrat$
	Model A	Model B
Constant	0.365 (0.282)	0.071 (0.052)
$\Delta\%Evangelical$	-2.772 (1.570)	1.084*** (0.139)
$Evangelical_{t-1}$	0.102 (0.258)	0.160 (0.148)
$\Delta\%Irreligious$	-8.509** (3.766)	1.029 (0.643)
$Irreligious_{t-1}$	-0.366 (0.395)	-0.039*** (0.008)
y_{t-1}	-0.414 (0.336)	-0.175 (0.129)
N	17	17
R-squared	0.860	0.998
Adj. R-squared	0.796	0.997
Residual Std. Error (df = 11)	0.002	0.0003
F Statistic (df = 5; 11)	13.486***	962.594***

***p < .01; **p < .05; *p < .1

6 Findings

Descriptively, taking all surveys into account, the Irreligious population has been growing significantly, going from an estimated 10% in 2006 to 35% in 2023. The confidence interval for Irreligion overlaps that of Catholicism, which means that it's entirely possible that Irreligion has already overtaken Catholicism as the largest religion in the Latino community. On the other hand, Evangelicalism has not grown at all, and neither have other Protestants or other religions. This suggests that some of the rhetoric around the magnitude Latino Evangelicals' influence on politics may be overblown.

Hypotheses 1 and 2 are tested on Table 2. For hypothesis 2, change in Irreligion will have a greater effect than change in Evangelicalism on change in Catholicism, Model A shows some support. Change in irreligion is negatively correlated with change in Catholicism, suggesting that the decrease in Catholicism is in some part explained by the increase in Irreligion. The coefficient for change in Evangelicalism shows that if an effect were to be significant, change in Evangelicalism would still have less effect on change in Catholicism than the effect from change in Irreligion. Thus, the null is rejected for Hypothesis 2.

Hypothesis 1 is tested in Model B, where there is not very much support. Change in Evangelicalism is found to be significant, but in the wrong direction. Additionally, the R^2 of 99.7% casts doubt on the usefulness of model B. I think the problem is that the Loess curves for both Democrat and Evangelical do not move very much.

From a face validity standpoint, these two curves probably do not correlate with

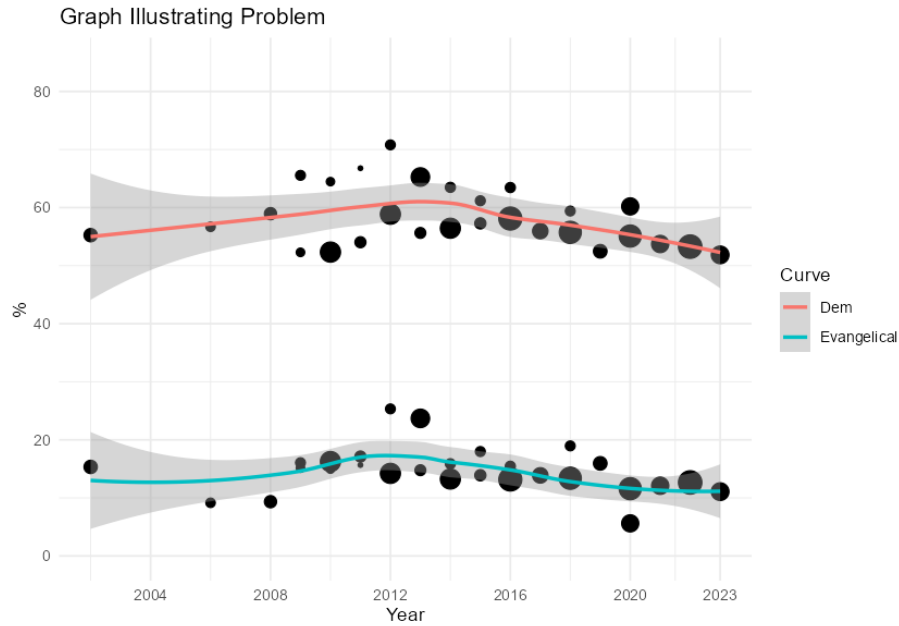


Figure 4

each other because Evangelicals are not Democrats (shown later). My broader concern is that when change in Democrat identification nears zero, the error correction model can find any term to be significant in explaining a near-zero Δ term as a dependent variable. I think that Model B should not be considered. However, I think it is fair to say that if Democrat identification hasn't changed, no variable can have an effect on this lack of change. The more important finding is that change in Irreligiosity, on balance, does not have an effect on change in Democrat identification.

The test for hypothesis 3 also faces some issues, though with reliability.

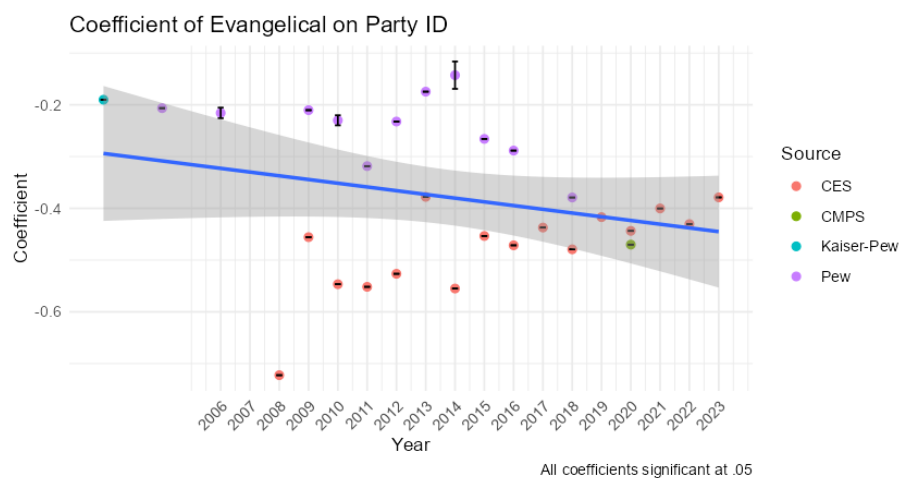


Figure 5

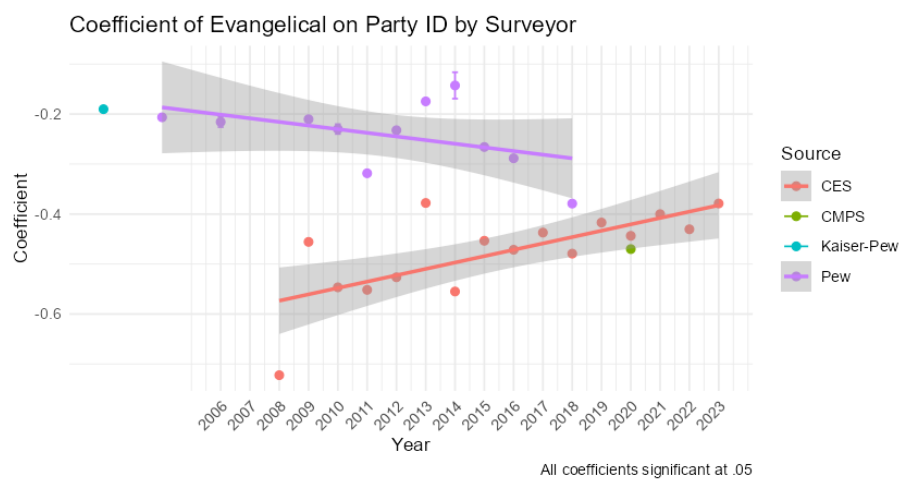


Figure 6

As can be seen from figure 5, no significant effect is found for the coefficient of Evangelicalism becoming more Republican. However, a major problem here comes from the data. This is an example of there being no solution to the differences in the Pew and CCES data. From figure 6, there appears to be two different effects. If the Pew data is taken alone, it seems that the effect of Evangelicalism is becoming more Republican, whereas if the CCES data is taken alone, the effect of Evangelicalism is becoming *significantly* less Republican. Given this data limitation, I cannot pass judgment on Hypothesis 3 at this time.

7 Discussion

I think that the most interesting findings are those that go against some of the precepts of the Defectors book. Unlike forecasted (Ramos 2024, chapter 4), Latinos are not becoming more Evangelical, nor are Latino Evangelicals becoming more Republican, controlling for other variables. Most of the decline in Catholicism is correlated with the rise of Irreligion, not Evangelicalism. In terms of politics, Democrat party identification is not changing very much, though it is currently slightly on the downturn. I don't believe that the lack of change can be attributed to anything in particular.

Though the results of this research study are somewhat underwhelming, given the limitations in the data, there are some broader implications for Latino politics. The changing religious landscape of Latinos is not deeply affecting party identification; if it were, we would expect an increase, rather than a decrease, in Democrat identification. As the erosion of the traditional Latino Catholic church continues, it

is likely that many of those who leave remain Democrat. This raises future questions as to socialization in these institutions shifting to other domains. The rising Evangelical movement in the Latino community is not actually rising at all, and likely have no effect on broader Democrat identification. Though religion is an important axis through which politics can be studied, it seems that even vast changes in religion are not effecting Latino politics to a great extent.

8 Conclusion

Momentous changes are happening in the world of Latino religions. The precipitous drop in Catholicism has coincided with a storming rise in Irreligion. During this shift, Democrat party identification has largely remained unchanged. Previous literature suggests that Irreligious people are more likely to be Democrat than Catholics (Gibson and Hare 2012), yet this does not seem to translate to the time-series of Democrat party identification in the Latino community at large. Though Latino Republican Evangelicals have caused a stir in the discursive space of Latino politics (Ramos 2024), they are not found to be growing in number, or becoming more Republican. Thus, I am left with the conclusion that, broadly, religion has not had an outsized impact on Latino party identification in the last 20 years.

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